
Designing for Maintainability

Goal. Get a hands-on experience with real-world commit messages (and software maintenance in general) and think critically about them.

1 The Apache Arrow project

First, take a quick look at the Apache Arrow project: <https://github.com/apache/arrow>, which is a framework for developing data analytics applications.

2 Reading some git commit messages

Now, let's take a closer look at some of the commit messages in this project.

First, clone the project: `git clone https://github.com/apache/arrow`

Then, go to the repo: `cd arrow`

Now, check some recent commit messages: `git log -5 --before ``March 10 2023```. This gives 5 recent commits after the specified date. You can use your arrow keys to scroll up and down.

Please spend a few minutes reading these commit messages, pretending you're a maintainer who has to understand the codebase and these commits. Identify at least one strength and one weakness of each of the commit messages (e.g., in terms of its readability, whether it lists "why", etc.).

3 Ranking commit messages

Now, note down the strengths/weaknesses you have discovered. Feel free to discuss with your partners. Also consider ranking them in terms of which you would most rather see, if you were to maintain this codebase.